

Strategic Competition in the Age of AI: Risks and Opportunities in Military Applications

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Executive summary

Military organizations worldwide are integrating artificial intelligence into planning, logistics and intelligence analysis at an accelerating pace. This report summarizes emerging risks and opportunities associated with that trend, drawing on open-source policy analysis rather than classified sources.

Four building-block competitions frame the analysis: quantity versus quality of deployed systems, the balance between hiding and finding assets on a contested battlefield, centralized versus decentralized command and control, and the evolving balance between cyber offense and cyber defense.

Quantity versus quality

Cheaper autonomous systems allow forces to field larger numbers of expendable platforms, shifting some engagements from a few high-value assets toward swarms of lower-cost units. This changes cost-exchange ratios in ways that established doctrine has not fully absorbed.

At the same time, higher-quality sensor fusion and targeting algorithms increase the effectiveness of each individual platform, so quantity and quality improvements can reinforce one another rather than substitute for each other.

Command and control

Centralized architectures offer tighter coordination but create a single point of failure if communications are degraded. Decentralized, AI-assisted decision-making at the edge can preserve operational tempo under contested conditions, at the cost of reduced central oversight.

Several allied doctrine documents now explicitly discuss hybrid architectures that shift authority dynamically depending on the communications environment, a design pattern borrowed from commercial distributed systems.

Policy recommendations

The report recommends independent verification and validation protocols for AI systems prior to fielding, sustained investment in workforce training, and multilateral dialogue on norms for AI-enabled targeting to reduce the risk of unintended escalation between competing powers.